

Digital Silence in Hybrid Higher Education:

Learner Engagement Beyond Cameras, Chats, and Attendance Logs

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12 minutes + 3 minutes Q&A

Opening scene: the class is present, but the screen is quiet



A full attendance log can still feel like an empty classroom.

camera off | mic muted | chat empty

The study begins from this puzzle: students may be digitally present without showing the usual public signs of participation.

Research move: read silence before judging it.

Grounded in the paper introduction and related work on online silence and interaction gaps [1], [2], [4], [5].

The scholarly problem: access is not the same as participation

Hybrid higher education has expanded digital access through platforms, LMSs, recordings, discussion boards, messaging applications, and digital assessment.

Yet access to digital spaces does not always lead to meaningful participation.

What teachers can see

attendance logs, camera use, microphone responses, chat posts, forum activity, LMS clicks

What those traces may hide

reflection, anxiety, privacy protection, unequal access, weak design, alienation, resistance, withdrawal

What this paper adds

silence as a diagnostic signal for pedagogy, access, inclusion, and quality assurance

Contribution in one sentence: the paper shifts digital silence from a deficit label to an interpretive category for hybrid pedagogy.

Problem and contribution from the abstract, introduction, discussion, and conclusion.

Theoretical positioning: three lenses for reading silence

1. Engagement is shaped

Engagement is influenced by psychological, social, structural, and institutional factors. Silence is therefore not only an individual weakness.

Kahu [6]

2. Presence is designed

Community of Inquiry explains online learning through teaching presence, social presence, and cognitive presence. Silence may hide or weaken these presences.

Garrison et al. [7]

3. Non-posting has meaning

Lurking and online silence may be engaged, purposeful, absorbed, relational, protective, ordinary, troublesome, or political.

Dennen [1], Duran [2], Kuhn et al. [3]

Scholarly stance: digital silence is a situated learner behaviour shaped by confidence, access, design, teacher presence, and learning culture.

This framing prevents the study from reducing silence to laziness, poor motivation, or passive attendance.

Literature base: student engagement [6], Community of Inquiry [7], pedagogical lurking and online silence [1]-[3].

Research design: a focused qualitative evidence trail

15 undergraduate participants with hybrid or online learning experience

2 data sources: open-ended questionnaire and semi-structured interviews

1 analysis approach: thematic analysis with repeated reading and theme review

Sampling logic

Purposive sampling selected students who had used video conferencing platforms, LMSs, WhatsApp learning groups, discussion spaces, recordings, and digital submission systems.

Questionnaire focus

Camera use, microphone participation, chat responses, forum posting, attendance, teacher feedback, peer interaction, and access to technology.

Interview focus

Reasons for silence, emotions, access challenges, learning preferences, belonging, teacher presence, and preferred participation modes.

Ethics: informed consent, anonymity, voluntary participation, and the right to withdraw.

Methodology from the paper.

Analytical move: from traces to meanings



Visible traces

camera use
mic use
chat posts
forum activity
attendance

Interpretive questions

Is the learner thinking?
Is visibility risky?
Is access unequal?
Is design suppressing response?

Learner meanings

reflection
protection
anxiety
belonging
withdrawal

Pedagogical response

low-pressure entry
inclusive norms
structured interaction
teacher presence
equitable modes

The study treats silence as data to be interpreted, not noise to be removed.

Synthesis based on methodology, findings, and proposed diagnostic framework.

Finding 1: silence moves on a continuum of visibility

The same visible behaviour, silence, may represent different levels of engagement.

At one end, students may be silently engaged: listening, reading messages, taking notes, following peers, preparing answers privately, or learning through observation.

At the other end, silence may show anxiety, exposure, technical restriction, feeling ignored, emotional detachment, or minimal attendance.

The key contribution is the distinction between invisible engagement and silent withdrawal.

Do not rush from silence to judgement.

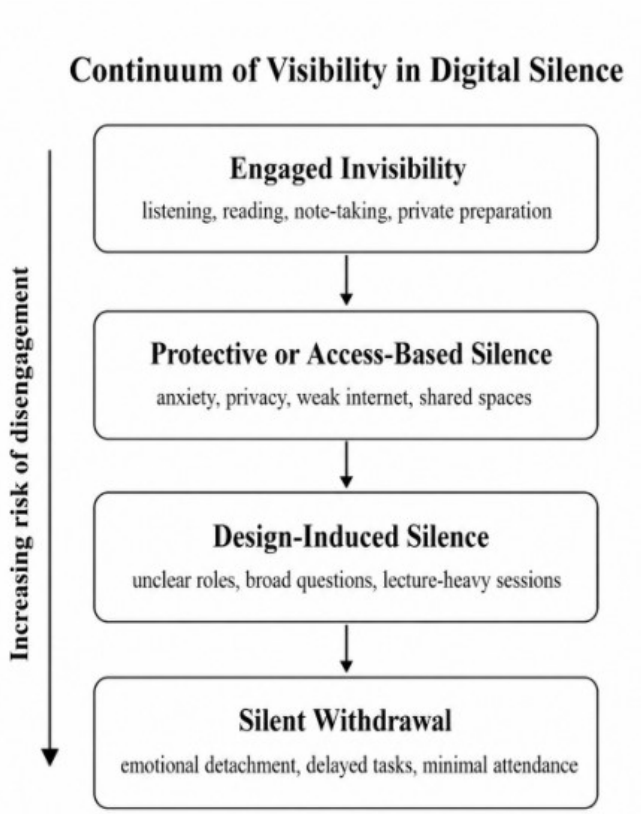


Figure 1 and findings section of the paper.

Finding 2: five forms of digital silence

The study shows that digital silence is not one category. Each form needs a different pedagogical reading.

Reflective	Protective	Access-based	Design-induced	Withdrawal
thinking processing preparing responses	mistakes peer judgement privacy domestic exposure	weak internet limited devices data costs shared spaces	lecture-heavy sessions broad questions unclear roles mechanical forums	emotional detachment delayed tasks minimal attendance
1	2	3	4	5

A single attendance metric cannot tell these five silences apart.

Five forms of silence from the findings section.

Finding 3: three higher-order insights

Visibility-pressure paradox

Students wanted teachers to recognise their effort, presence, and difficulties. Yet the usual signs of online engagement, such as cameras, verbal answers, chat posts, and instant responses, also created pressure.

Key insight: students wanted to be noticed, but not exposed.

Hybrid in-betweenness

Hybrid learning was not always experienced as a smooth blend. Some learners felt suspended between online and face-to-face spaces, officially present but socially peripheral.

Key insight: hybrid presence can produce marginality.

Layered participation

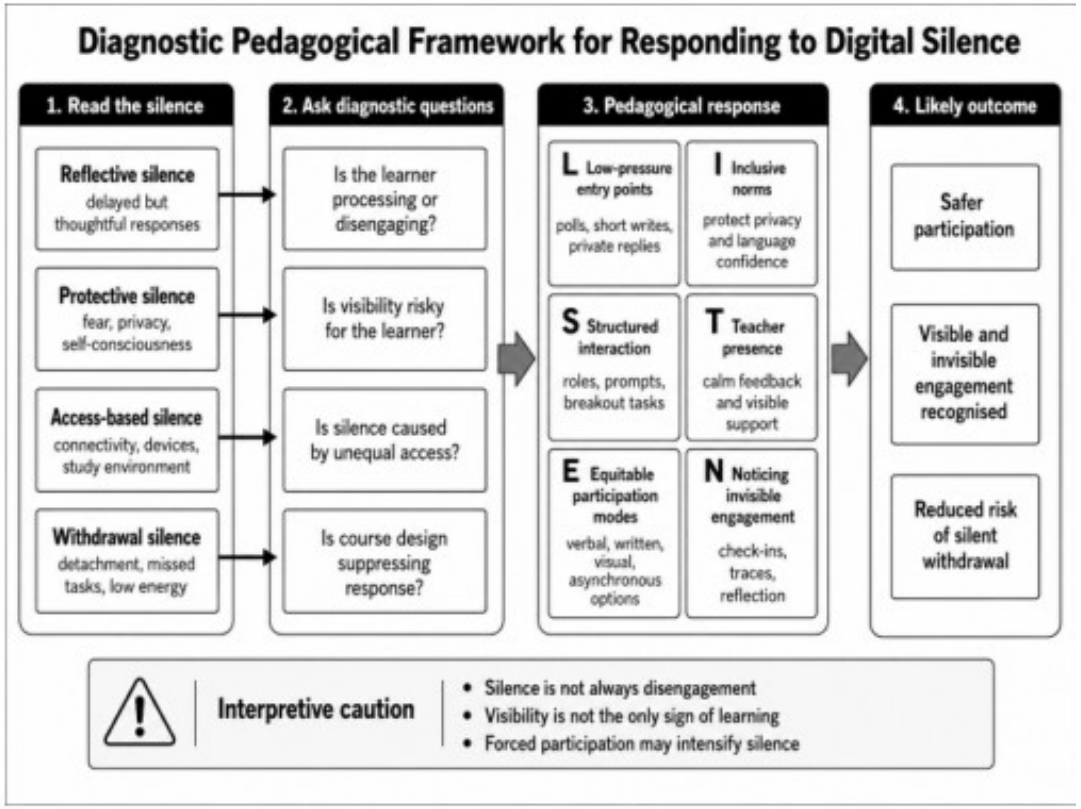
Students were more willing to participate when interaction moved gradually from low-risk to higher-risk modes: polls, private messages, short written responses, shared documents, small groups, then public speaking.

Key insight: participation is a risk ladder.

Advanced contribution: digital engagement is not simply visibility. It is negotiated through risk, recognition, access, design, and belonging.

Higher-order findings from the findings and discussion sections.

From finding to framework: responding through LISTEN



L — **Low-pressure entry points**
polls, short writes, private replies

I — **Inclusive norms**
privacy, confidence, safety

S — **Structured interaction**
roles, prompts, breakout tasks

T — **Teacher presence**
feedback and visible support

E — **Equitable participation modes**
verbal, written, visual, async

N — **Noticing invisible engagement**
check-ins, traces, reflection

Framework logic: read the silence → ask diagnostic questions → choose a safer response → reduce silent withdrawal.

Figure 2 from the paper: Diagnostic pedagogical framework for responding to digital silence.

What this changes for hybrid higher education



Attendance logs, cameras, microphones, chats, and LMS clicks are traces of participation, not complete evidence of learning.

For teachers

Design participation as a gradual process: polls, private responses, short written tasks, small groups, and reflection before public speaking.

For institutions

Treat engagement as pedagogy, access, emotional safety, digital inclusion, and belonging, not only platform activity.

For QA

Use visible indicators carefully. They need contextual interpretation before they become evidence of quality.

Shift the question from "Why are they silent?" to "What conditions would make participation safer, flexible, and meaningful?"

Discussion, implications, and conclusion of the paper.

Closing argument

Connection is not the same as participation.

Conceptual contribution

A continuum of visibility that separates invisible engagement from silent withdrawal.

Empirical contribution

Five forms of digital silence and three higher-order insights from undergraduate experiences.

Pedagogical contribution

A diagnostic LISTEN framework for safer and more flexible participation.

The strongest question is not “Why are students silent?”
It is “What is the silence telling us?”

Thank you. Questions and discussion.

[1] Dennen, 2008 | [2] Duran, 2020 | [3] Kuhn et al., 2021 | [4] Ho et al., 2023
[5] Yarmand et al., 2021 | [6] Kahu, 2013 | [7] Garrison et al., 2000